

location to enable innovation. The focus now is to establish such robust ecosystems across the state.

“We believe in the 3I mantra—innovation, infrastructure and inclusivity—that will be the road map to nurture a robust environment for entrepreneurship in the 33 districts of the state,” says K. T. Rama Rao, Telangana’s Minister for IT, Industries & Commerce. He adds that while the state keeps innovating through frameworks and policies to target start-ups from various sectors, it also builds infrastructure to decentralise the efforts into Tier II and III cities. “We currently have IT towers with state-of-the-art facilities operational in Warangal, Karimnagar and Khammam districts, all for inclusive growth. In the next 25 years we look forward to identifying talent and creating entrepreneurs from all the corners of Telangana irrespective of the demography and geography,” says Rao.

Many state governments have been working hard to promote innovation and technological advancement by creating incubators, accelerators and Centres of Excellence (CoEs), either on their own or in partnership with private organisations. They have also been building COEs in cutting-edge technologies, and providing specialised facilities to support specific industries.

“Odisha, particularly Bhubaneswar, has emerged as an educational hub during the last one and a half decades. The state has been a top destination for domain-specific R&D organisations. To leverage these institutional infrastructures, the Startup Odisha policy placed a strong focus on academic and research organisations,” says Omkar Rai, Executive Chairman of Startup Odisha. He adds that the state has 15 R&D institutions which act as nodal agencies in their particular segment



“Karnataka’s vision is to become a champion state for start-ups and foster high growth of 25,000-plus start-ups in the coming years”

C.N. ASHWATH NARAYAN

MINISTER OF ELECTRONICS, INFORMATION & BIOTECHNOLOGY AND SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY, GOVERNMENT OF KARNATAKA



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K.T. RAMA RAO

MINISTER FOR IT, INDUSTRIES & COMMERCE, GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA



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ABHISHEK TIWARI

ADVISOR, STARTINUP PROGRAM, GOVERNMENT OF UTTAR PRADESH

and “supports us in evaluation and mentoring of start-ups in their respective domains”.

In Uttar Pradesh, the state introduced a new, dedicated Startup Policy 2020 with an aim to build 100 incubators covering all the 75 districts in the state. Abhishek Tiwari, Advisor to the StartInUP Program of the UP government, says that UP is a large state with four to five times more people than other strong start-up states and multiple cities that are of a “similar stature”. “We wanted to involve more people and spread the ecosystem across the state,” he says.

With an aim to create India’s largest incubation network, UP has so far established 55 incubators across 23 districts. The new policy also aims to generate 150,000 job opportunities. Tiwari says that there is at least one start-up present in every district in the state. UP has also established three CoEs—for artificial intelligence at IIT Kanpur, at its Noida outreach campus; for drone technology at IIT Kanpur; and for medtech at Sanjay Gandhi Post Graduate Institute of Medical Sciences in Lucknow—and five more are being established in sectors such as quantum computing, spacetechnology, 5G/6G, additive manufacturing and blockchain.

Meanwhile, the Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM)—the central agency of the Government of Kerala for entrepreneurship development and incubation activities—has a strong network of innovation and entrepreneurship development centres (IEDCs) in universities and colleges. There are over 375 IEDCs or mini-incubators—that work as launch pads for ‘studentpreneurs’—actively operating in the state. The government is also setting up innovation zones in government departments like Kerala State Electricity Board and Kerala Water Authority to iden-